The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Marcin Nowak/LNP

Peter Mandelson was arrested on suspicion of misconduct in public office after he was accused of sharing confidential government documents with Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender. Files released by America's Justice Department appeared to show Lord Mandelson passing official information to Epstein while a cabinet minister. Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, brother of King Charles III, was arrested on similar grounds last week.

Mexico's security minister said criminal gangs have killed at least 25 soldiers in retaliatory attacks since the death of the leader of the **Jalisco New Generation Cartel**, the country's most notorious drug-trafficking gang. Unrest has spread across at least 20 states since Nemesio Rubén Oseguera Cervantes (aka "El Mencho") died after being caught by the Mexican army on Sunday.

American stock indices dropped amid tariff uncertainty and a continued **software sell-off** triggered by AI concerns. The S&P 500 and the tech-heavy Nasdaq fell by more than 1%. **Donald Trump** announced global tariffs of 15% after the Supreme Court struck down the bulk of his levies. He threatened higher tariffs for countries that "play games". Earlier Europe paused ratifying its American trade deal.

America's armed forces said they struck another alleged **drug-trafficking boat** in the **Caribbean**, killing three "narco-terrorists". It is the third attack in the region this month; 150 people have been killed by American strikes on boats in the Caribbean and the Pacific since September. Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, is due to travel to the Caribbean for security discussions this week.

European officials criticised **Hungary** for threatening to block planned EU sanctions on Russia and a €90bn ($106bn) loan to Ukraine. Hungary and Slovakia accuse Ukraine of impeding imports of Russian oil across its territory. Poland's foreign minister, Radoslaw Sikorski, said Viktor Orban, Hungary's pro-Russia prime minister, was smearing Ukraine as a campaigning tool ahead of his country's elections in April.

Novo Nordisk's shares slumped by more than 16% after trial data for a new weight-loss jab showed it was less effective than a similar product from its American rival, Eli Lilly. The Danish drugmaker's share price has steadily declined since 2024 as Lilly has taken a bigger bite of the lucrative obesity-drug market. The results are a blow to Novo's plan to turn around its fortunes.

Anthropic accused three Chinese AI firms of using fake accounts to generate millions of exchanges with its Claude chatbot to help their smaller models learn from stronger ones. Anthropic said Chinese firms deployed the tactic to "illicitly extract" data and bypass America's export controls on AI technology. Anthropic called for industry-wide response, echoing recent warnings from OpenAI about Chinese companies free-riding on American-developed systems.

Figure of the day: 1.1m, the approximate number of cars manufactured in Slovakia in 2025—more than anywhere else in the world per person. Read the full story.

Photograph: Reuters

Four years of fighting in Ukraine

As Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine enters its fifth year on Tuesday, hopes of a breakthrough in peace negotiations are low. The latest round of trilateral talks, which involve American go-betweens, ended abruptly in Geneva last week.

The most intractable disagreement is about territory. Russia is demanding that Ukraine cede the 20% of eastern Donetsk, which includes the well-defended "fortress belt", that it has failed to take by force. Such a concession would cross a Ukrainian red line. President Zelensky accused the Russians of having dragged out the talks and lecturing: "I don't need historical shit to end this war," he posted on X.

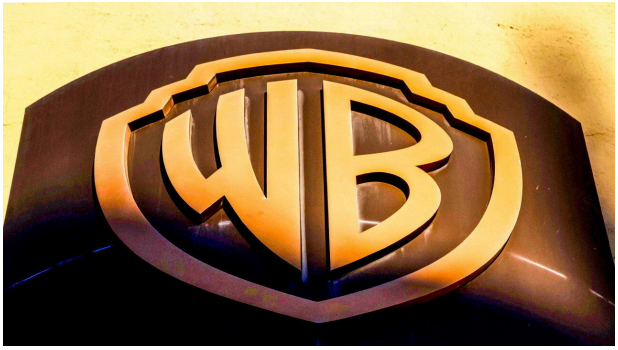
Donald Trump is pushing for a deal by June. But European intelligence agencies are reportedly pessimistic about the chances of an agreement this year—despite Russia's excruciatingly slow progress on the battlefield and stalling economy, Vladimir Putin, its president, does not yet seem to feel enough pressure to end his war.

Photograph: Hans Lucas/AFP via Getty Images

Europe mulls its response to Trump's tariffs

This week European parliamentarians will discuss the latest developments in Europe's trade tussle with Donald Trump. On Saturday America's president said that he would raise temporary tariffs on imports from all countries from 10% to 15%. That was his response to the Supreme Court's ruling the day before that many of his tariffs are illegal.

The European Union sees the substitute tariffs as a violation of its trade deal with the American government, which was initially agreed to in July 2025, pending ratification by the European Parliament. The EU put ratification on hold in January, after Mr Trump threatened additional levies on European countries that opposed his plan to acquire Greenland. The ratification vote, rescheduled for Tuesday, is likely to be delayed again. "As the United States' largest trading partner, the EU expects the US to honour its commitments," said the EU executive in an unusually strongly worded statement on Sunday. "A deal is a deal."



Photograph: Getty Images

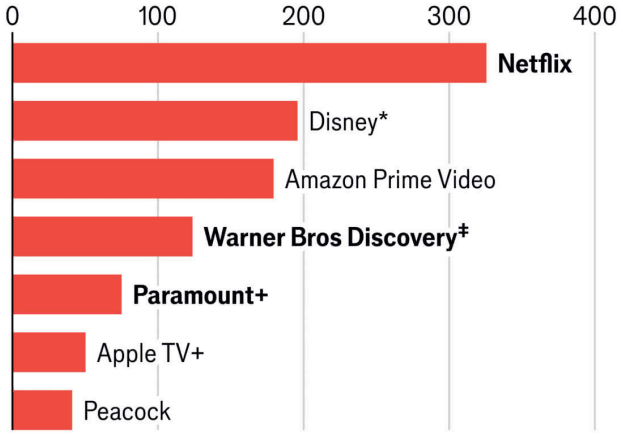
The final episode of the Warner Bros battle

Bring the popcorn. On Monday Paramount Skydance is expected to make its best—and final—offer to buy Warner Bros Discovery. In December the entertainment firm's board rejected Paramount's advances in favour of a bid from Netflix, a streaming giant. That has not put off Paramount. It suggested that it may raise its offer to more than $31 per share for the entirety of Warner, compared with Netflix's $27.8 bid for its streaming platform and studios.

Warner's board says it remains committed to Netflix. Its shareholders are divided over which suitor is more likely to secure regulatory approval for a deal. Paramount is the smaller buyer, and the friendship between its owners, the Ellison family, and President Donald Trump could help. (European and British regulators also need to give their nod.) Netflix says it would not dominate the television sector even after a merger. The saga will move into its next season on March 20th, when Warner's shareholders are due to vote.

No business like showbusiness

Global streaming subscriptions, m
Selected companies, Q3 2025



*Disney+, Disney+ Hotstar and Hulu
‡Discovery+ and HBO Max
Source: Ampere Analysis

Photograph: Getty Images

Duterte chooses a jail cell over a courtroom

On Monday the International Criminal Court in The Hague began a week of hearings to determine whether there is enough evidence to put Rodrigo Duterte, a former president of the Philippines, on trial for crimes against humanity. These include murders allegedly committed during his campaign against the trade in illegal drugs, which killed at least 6,000 suspects. (He denies the charges.)

The ICC is letting Mr Duterte remain in the jail cell he has occupied for 11 months rather than insisting that he attend the hearings. However, the court pointedly ignored the 80-year-old ex-president's personal submission that he is too "old, tired and frail" to attend. If the judges put him on trial, expect his lawyers to make that argument more loudly.

Photograph: DPA

Germany’s fragile economic recovery

German business sentiment beat expectations in February, a survey by the Ifo Institute for Economic Research showed on Monday. The think-tank’s business-sentiment index rose to 88.6 in February, from 87.6 in January. The Ifo Institute’s president, Clemens Fuest, said the German economy is “showing the first signs of a recovery”.

Still, business conditions remain fragile. Last month the government of Friedrich Merz downgraded its forecast for growth this year from 1.3% to 1%. The government’s large increase in spending on rearmament and infrastructure is starting to create growth in construction and manufacturing, but it remains unclear whether it will lead to a sustainable recovery. Meanwhile, high energy and labour costs and geopolitical risks, particularly the escalation of trade tensions with America, are hurting the export-oriented German economy. And makers of cars and machinery, among the champions of German industry, are still figuring out how to compete against upstart Chinese rivals.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which American statesman who was secretary of state under Richard Nixon died in 2023 at the age of 100?

The cost of liberty is less than the price of repression.

W. E. B. Du Bois